

Attention Dilution: A Mechanistic Analysis of Context-Length Jailbreaks and Activation Steering in LLMs

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Abstract

Safety-tuned language models that reliably refuse harmful requests in isolation often comply with the same requests when buried in long benign context. We ask why, mechanistically, in Qwen3-14B. Following Ardit et al. [2024] we extract a single refusal direction $\hat{d}$ in the residual stream by difference-of-means and identify the dominant “Guardrail Head” L36H31 by direct logit attribution. Sweeping six bloat formats (prefix, suffix, sandwich, distractor, multi-turn, many-shot) at context lengths N up to 4096 tokens, we find that **prompt structure, not raw token count, determines whether refusal fails**: only the *distractor* (numbered-list) format collapses refusal, doing so at just ~ 31 tokens, while four of the other five formats preserve refusal at $\geq 87\%$ even at $N=4096$ (*suffix* degrades partially to 0.59). We then show the failure is **attentional, not representational**: L36H31’s attention mass on the harmful tokens drops $6\times$ between $N=0$ and $N=4096$, while $\hat{d}$ itself is unaltered. A single-site $\alpha\cdot\hat{d}$ rescue at the read-off layer fails because the $\hat{d}$ -projection at the last token actually **inverts sign** under dilution. Denoising path patching localizes the upstream lesion to a single attention head, **L20H10**, defining a two-head circuit ($L20H10 \rightarrow L36H31$) whose silencing under dilution causes the behavioral collapse. A four-experiment validity battery confirms $\hat{d}$ encodes harm intent rather than verb-class, length, lexicon, or topic artefacts.

1 Introduction

Long-context language models are increasingly deployed in agentic and multi-turn settings where a harmful request may sit at the end of tens of thousands of benign tokens. A growing body of work [Anil et al., 2024, Liu et al., 2024] shows that safety-tuned models which reliably refuse a harmful request in isolation comply with

the same request once it is buried in enough surrounding context. This is a safety-relevant failure mode: the same RLHF-trained refusal behavior that passes red-team evaluations at short context silently degrades as context grows, and the degradation is invisible to standard benchmarks that test prompts in isolation.

This paper asks a mechanistic question rather than a behavioral one. We already know jailbreaks work; we want to know *why*, at the level of attention heads and residual-stream directions. The original hypothesis, following Ardit et al. [2024] and Anil et al. [2024], was that softmax dilution generally drowns out the refusal signal as N grows. Our results refine this picture in three ways: the effect is *format-conditional* rather than length-conditional; the failure is *attentional* rather than representational; and the single-direction rescue widely promoted in the steering literature [Turner et al., 2023, Panickssery et al., 2024] fails for a quantifiable reason, the projection onto $\hat{d}$ inverts sign under dilution, placing the residual far in the anti-refusal half-space.

Contributions.

1. **A causal refusal direction in Qwen3-14B** at layer $\ell^*=36$, identified by strict ablation criterion (Section 4.1), validated against four confound controls (Section 5).
2. **Format-conditional dilution.** Across six bloat formats at N up to 4096, only the *distractor* format breaks refusal, at a jailbreak threshold of ~ 31 tokens (Sections 6 and 7).
3. **Attentional, not representational.** The dominant Guardrail Head L36H31 loses $6\times$ of its attention mass on the harmful tokens under dilution, while $\hat{d}$ itself stays intact (Section 9).
4. **The single-site rescue fails, and we explain why.** At $N \geq 512$, no $\alpha \in \{0, \dots, 16\}$ restores refusal. Path patching reveals that the $\hat{d}$ projection at L36’s last token *inverts sign* under dilution and localizes the upstream lesion to a single head **L20H10**, defining

*Code and reproduction artifacts: https://github.com/ayushkokande/attention_dilution.

a two-head circuit $L20H10 \rightarrow L36H31$ (Sections A.4 and 10).

2 Related Work

Refusal as a single direction. Arditi et al. [2024] show that refusal in instruction-tuned LLMs is mediated by a single direction in residual space, extractable via difference-of-means between harmful and harmless prompt activations. Wollschläger et al. [2025] extend this to multi-directional refusal subspaces. Zhao et al. [2025] report that *harmfulness* and *refusal* are encoded at different token positions (instruction vs. post-instruction), supporting our finding that the failure is at the read-off layer rather than at the harmfulness representation.

Guardrail heads. Jin et al. [2024] identify specific attention heads (e.g. L21H14 in Llama2-7B, L31H35 in Llama2-13B) that mediate refusal vs. affirmation. We replicate this style of identification in Qwen3-14B and find L36H31 as the dominant Guardrail Head.

Long-context jailbreaks. Anil et al. [2024] demonstrate that filling context with many in-context exemplars defeats safety tuning. Liu et al. [2024] document general degradation of long-context recall. Our work mechanistically explains *why* dilution attacks succeed by tying the behavioral collapse to head-level attention loss, and shows that the effect is conditional on prompt structure rather than absolute token count.

Activation steering and path patching. Turner et al. [2023] demonstrated that activation addition along learned directions can steer model behavior; Panickssery et al. [2024] formalize the technique. Our negative rescue result qualifies the practical reach of single-site steering under sufficient dilution. Goldowsky-Dill et al. [2023] introduced denoising path patching for circuit attribution, which we use to localize the upstream lesion.

3 Setup

Model. Qwen3-14B: 40 transformer blocks, 40 query heads (GQA, 8 KV heads), $d_{\text{model}}=5120$, 32K RoPE context window. We load with bf16 weights and `padding_side="left"` via HuggingFace `AutoModelForCausalLM` and `transformer_lens` [Nanda and Bloom, 2022] for hooked-residual / hooked-attention operations, on A100-80GB hardware. Qwen3 emits `<think>` blocks that pollute residual-stream activations and refusal scoring; we force `enable_thinking=False` at the chat template level and additionally strip any leading `<think>` block before scoring.

Data. Harmful prompts: the 520 prompts of AdvBench [Zou et al., 2023] `harmful_behaviors.csv`. Harmless prompts: Alpaca [Taori et al., 2023] train split, empty-input rows after a content filter, $n=23\,380$. Per-experiment row indices are pinned in `splits.json`; disjointness between $\hat{d}$ training and downstream evaluation pools is enforced (two documented overlap warnings, both flagged in Section A.2).

Refusal detector. We strip the leading `<think>...</think>` segment (Qwen3 reasoning trace), lowercase the first 200 characters of the remainder, and flag a refusal iff any of 18 canonical substrings (Section A.1.1) appears. Used for binary refusal-rate measurement in Experiments 1, 2 (downstream judge after ablation), 7 (preflight), and 8 (context sweep). The causal layer-selection sweep in Experiment 2 uses a stricter 26-substring variant (Section A.1.2) for replication fidelity. Projection-based validity tests (Experiments 3–6, 7-eval, 9) bypass the marker judge entirely and operate on continuous projections of last-token residuals onto $\hat{d}$.

Bloat formats. Six structures wrap the harmful request in benign material (Table 5, defined in Section 6). Across formats N denotes the token count of bloat material (excluding the harmful request itself).

3.1 Baseline refusal rates

Before any extraction or intervention, we measure the unconditioned refusal floor of the intact model on each pool with the canonical HF `AutoModelForCausalLM` stack: `bf16`, `device_map="auto"` across $2 \times A100$ -80GB, `left-padded` `batched` `greedy` `decode` (`temperature=0`, `max_new_tokens=512`, `batch_size=8`, `enable_thinking=False`) and the canonical 18-marker `looks_like_refusal` detector (Section A.1.1). Table 1 reports the headline numbers (`results/qwen3-14b/baseline_summary.json`; per-prompt outputs in `baseline_advbench.jsonl`, `baseline_alpaca.jsonl`; reproduction script `experiment_1/baseline_benchmark.py`). The harmless rate falls well below the ≤ 0.05 threshold required by Decision Rule 1, so layer selection has headroom. The harmful rate of 0.937 rather than ~ 1.0 gives a meaningful binary signal for the dilution sweep: there is room to move both up (under steering) and down (under context bloat).

Pool	n	refusal	compliance
AdvBench (harmful)	520	0.9365	0.0635
Alpaca (harmless)	512	0.0137	0.9863

Table 1: Unconditioned baseline refusal rates on Qwen3-14B, intact model with no hooks. AdvBench: full LLM-attacks `harmful_behaviors.csv` ($n=520$); Alpaca: empty-input rows of `tatsu-lab/alpaca[train]` after the `_harmless_instruction_is_clean` filter, capped at $n=512$. The harmful rate 0.9365 rounds to the 0.937 used inline; the harmless rate 0.0137 rounds to 0.014.

4 Method: Extracting and Validating the Refusal Direction

4.1 DiffMean extraction at every layer

We use difference-of-means [Arditi et al., 2024] rather than a gradient-based attribution method: DiffMean is per-head fast, scales trivially to a per-layer $\times$ per- N sweep, and admits a clean causal validation (project the direction out and watch refusal collapse), which gives the same “this is the responsible direction” claim that gradient attribution would supply at orders of magnitude lower compute. For each transformer block $\ell \in \{0, \dots, 39\}$, we cache the last-token residual stream over disjoint harmful and harmless training pools and compute

$$\hat{d}_\ell = \frac{\mu_\ell^{(\text{harmful})} - \mu_\ell^{(\text{harmless})}}{\|\mu_\ell^{(\text{harmful})} - \mu_\ell^{(\text{harmless})}\|_2}. \quad (1)$$

Training pools: AdvBench[100:356] ($n=256$ harmful) and Alpaca ($n=256$ harmless), disjoint from the held-out causal-ablation pool AdvBench[480:504] and from the downstream evaluation pools.

4.2 Causal-ablation criterion for layer selection

For each candidate layer, we project $\hat{d}_\ell$ out of the residual stream at the output of every transformer block (one forward-hook per DecoderLayer, 40 hooks total; equivalent to a `resid_post` ablation that propagates by induction into the `resid_pre` of the next block) during a forward pass on a 24-prompt held-out harmful pool, and measure post-ablation refusal rate. The canonical layer minimizes post-ablation harmful refusal subject to harmless refusal staying near zero.

Decision Rule 1 (Layer selection).
 $\ell^* = \arg \min_\ell \text{Refuse}_{\text{ablated}}^{(\text{harmful})}(\ell)$ subject to $\text{Refuse}_{\text{ablated}}^{(\text{harmless})}(\ell) \leq 0.05$, with deterministic tie-break by closeness to the peak-norm layer.

Result. For Qwen3-14B, the layer-sweep on candidate grid $\{14, 16, 18, \dots, 36\}$ over the 24-prompt held-out pool AdvBench[480, 504] produces post-ablation

Condition	Harmful	Harmless
intact (no hook)	0.860	0.000
ablated ($\hat{d}_{36}$ projected out at all 40 sites)	0.000	0.000

Table 2: Causal validation of $\hat{d}_{36}$ on disjoint 100-prompt eval pools. Removing $\hat{d}_{36}$ kills harmful refusal cleanly while inducing zero spurious benign refusals.

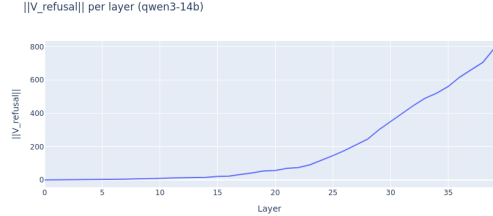


Figure 1: Per-layer norm $\|\mu_\ell^{(\text{harmful})} - \mu_\ell^{(\text{harmless})}\|_2$ of the unnormalized DiffMean direction in Qwen3-14B. The norm grows monotonically through mid-network and peaks at $\ell=39$. The peak-norm layer is not the causal optimum; we use Decision Rule 1 (strict ablation criterion with deterministic tie-break) and select $\ell^*=36$ as canonical.

harmful refusal at zero or near zero across $\ell \in \{18, 20, 24, 26, 28, 30, 32, 34, 36\}$, with one outlier at $\ell=22$ (0.708 post-ablate; an intrinsic instability of the diff-of-means geometry at that depth). Early candidates $\ell \in \{14, 16\}$ retain partial post-ablation refusal (0.750 and 0.250 respectively), confirming that $\hat{d}$ is not yet causally responsible at depth < 18 . The peak-norm layer is $\ell=39$ (Figure 1). Applying the tie-break we select $\ell^*=36$ as canonical: closest to the peak-norm layer among the satisficing candidates, 0.000 post-ablation harmful refusal, 0.000 post-ablation harmless refusal. Validation on a disjoint 100-prompt harmful pool gives intact-harmful refusal 0.86, ablated-harmful 0.00, intact-harmless 0.00, ablated-harmless 0.00, a clean directional ablation (Table 2). All downstream sections use $\ell^*=36$.

4.3 Identifying Guardrail Heads via direct logit attribution

With $\ell^*=36$ fixed, for each (ℓ, h) with $\ell \leq 36$ we project the head’s per-token contribution at the final instruction position onto $\hat{d}_{36}$ and average over 24 harmful prompts. Top-12 heads form the Guardrail Set (Table 3); a single head, **L36H31**, dominates ($+14.72, 2.15\times$ the next head).

Per-head attribution to V_refusal (qwen3-14b, read L36)

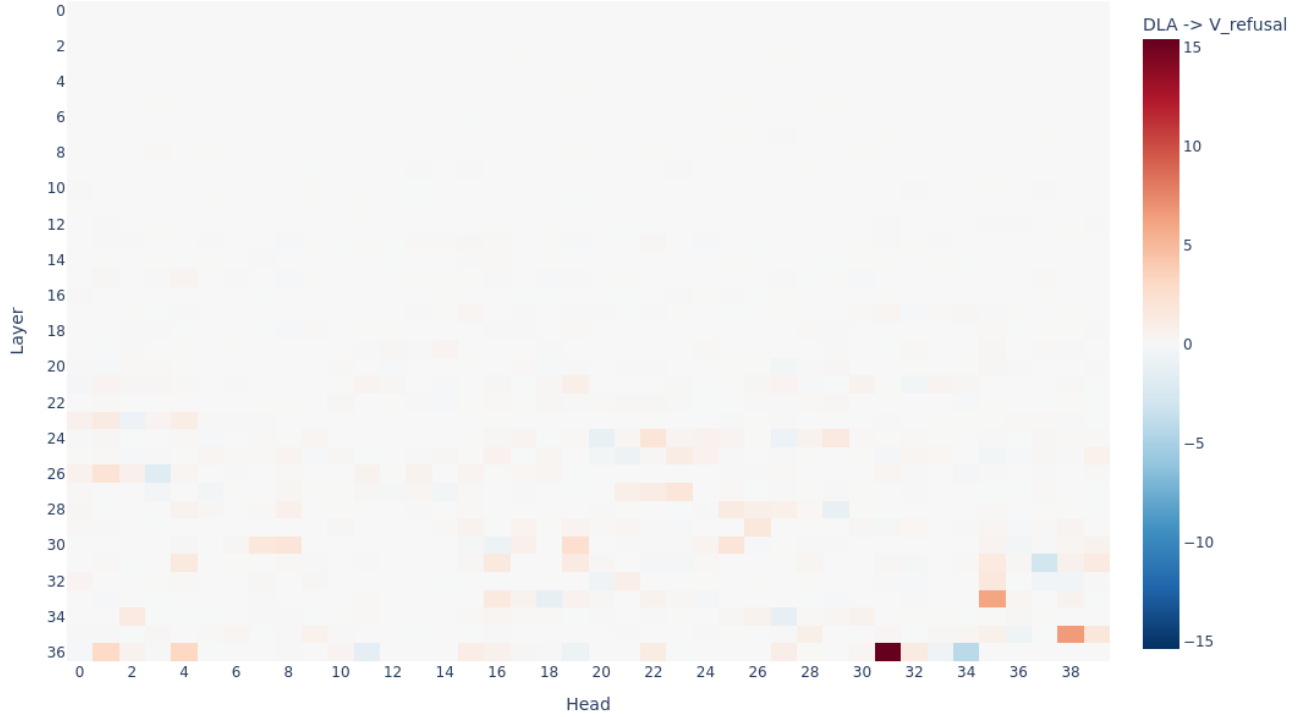


Figure 2: Per-head direct logit attribution onto $\hat{d}_{36}$ for all heads up to the read-off layer (rows: layer 0–36; columns: head 0–39). Red is positive contribution to refusal-promoting logits; blue is negative. **L36H31** is the single brightest cell; secondary positive heads cluster in mid-to-late layers ($\ell \in \{24, 26, 27, 30, 33, 35, 36\}$).

Head	DLA score	Head	DLA score
L36H31	+14.72	L30H19	+2.10
L35H38	+6.85	L30H08	+1.92
L33H35	+4.41	L35H39	+1.88
L36H01	+3.10	L24H22	+1.81
L36H04	+2.91	L27H23	+1.77
L26H01	+2.16	L30H25	+1.76

Table 3: Top-12 Guardrail Heads by direct logit attribution onto $\hat{d}_{36}$. L36H31 dominates by a wide margin and is the focus of the mechanistic analysis in Sections A.4 and 9. The full per-head DLA ranking is visualised in Figure 2 and Figure 18.

5 Disentangling $\hat{d}$ from Surface Confounds

A reviewer flagged that AdvBench and Alpaca differ in surface form (verb class, length, lexical register), so $\hat{d}$ may track domain shift rather than harm intent. We address this with four preregistered confound-control experiments, all run at canonical $\ell^*=36$ on $\hat{d}$ extracted

per Section 4.1, with a parallel arm on the matched-pool replication $\hat{d}^*$ (Section 5.1). Headline numbers are reported at canonical $\ell^*=36$.

5.1 Matched verb/length pools

We construct verb-class- and word-length-matched harmful/harmless pools, re-extract $\hat{d}^*$, and compute per-layer $\cos(\hat{d}, \hat{d}^*)$. A clean direction should produce a high-cosine $\hat{d}^*$ on the matched pools.

Decision Rule 2 (Matched pool). $\cos(\hat{d}, \hat{d}^*) \geq 0.90$ at the canonical layer $\Rightarrow$ clean. $\leq 0.70 \Rightarrow$ contaminated.

Result. $\cos(\hat{d}, \hat{d}^*) = 0.9748$ at canonical $\ell^*=36$ (refusal_direction_matched/compare_to_orig.json). The per-layer cosine sequence climbs from 0.69 at $\ell=0$ to a plateau ≥ 0.97 from $\ell=19$ onward (Figure 3); canonical $\ell^*=36$ sits well inside that plateau. Comfortably above the clean threshold; $\hat{d}$ does not collapse onto the verb-class / length confound.

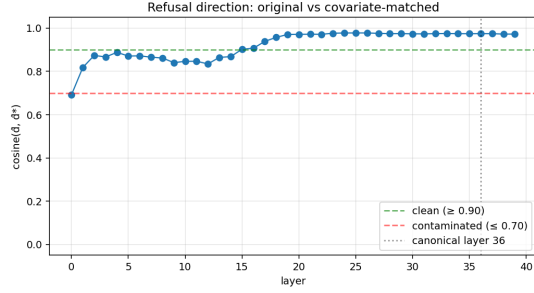


Figure 3: Per-layer $\cos(\hat{d}_\ell, \hat{d}_\ell^*)$ between the canonical AdvBench-vs-Alpaca direction $\hat{d}$ and the verb-class- and word-length-matched replication $\hat{d}^*$. The cosine plateau ≥ 0.97 from $\ell=19$ onward; the canonical read-out layer $\ell^*=36$ sits well inside the plateau, with $\cos(\hat{d}_{36}, \hat{d}_{36}^*) = 0.9748$. The early-layer dip (~ 0.69 at $\ell=0$) reflects pre-Diff-of-Means embedding geometry rather than a divergence in what the direction encodes.

5.2 Style/vocabulary mismatch

We construct an “edgy harmless” pool (benign tasks phrased with the same lexical register as AdvBench) and a “camouflaged harmful” pool (AdvBench requests rewritten in mild, neutral language), and project residuals onto $\hat{d}$. We compute two AUCs: $\text{AUC}_{\text{intent}}$ ranks prompts by harm intent (camouflaged-harmful as positive class), $\text{AUC}_{\text{vocab}}$ ranks prompts by edgy-lexicon density.

Decision Rule 3 (Style/vocabulary). $\text{AUC}_{\text{intent}} \geq 0.85$ AND $\text{AUC}_{\text{vocab}} \in [0.35, 0.65]$ (preregistered chance band).

Result. At canonical $\ell^*=36$, $\text{AUC}_{\text{intent}} = 1.000$ and $\text{AUC}_{\text{vocab}} = 0.597$ on $\hat{d}$ (matched $\hat{d}^*$: $\text{AUC}_{\text{vocab}} = 0.536$; `validity/auc.json`). Both vocab AUCs sit inside the preregistered chance band $[0.35, 0.65]$ while intent AUC saturates at 1.000. Verdict **intent-driven** (the direction reads prompt meaning, not surface lexicon, it fires on softly-phrased harm and stays silent on edgy-tone benign prompts): projection tracks harmful intent; edgy-vocab association is at chance (Figure 4).

5.3 Topic decoupling

We split prompts on two axes, harm intent (harmful vs. harmless) and topic tone (edgy vs. mundane), and ask whether $\hat{d}$ fires on intent or on topic. For each prompt we project the residual onto $\hat{d}$ and run a 2×2 ANOVA, reporting partial η^2 for each factor and their interaction.

Decision Rule 4 (Topic decoupling). Partial $\eta^2(\text{intent}) \geq 0.5$ AND $\eta^2(\text{topic}) \leq 0.1$.

Result. At canonical $\ell^*=36$ on $\hat{d}$, $\eta^2(\text{intent}) = 0.963$, $\eta^2(\text{topic}) = 0.094$, $\eta^2(\text{intent:topic}) = 0.002$ (`topic_decouple/anova.json`). The intent effect is

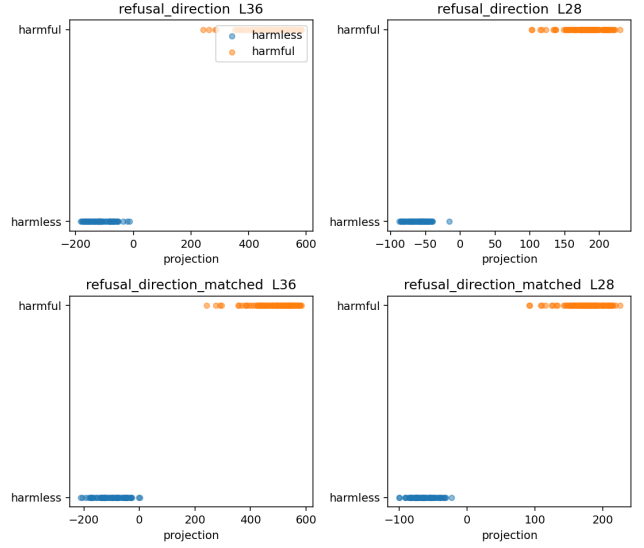


Figure 4: Style/vocabulary 2×2 design: per-prompt projection on $\hat{d}$ (AdvBench-canonical) and $\hat{d}^*$ (matched-pool) at $\ell^*=36$ and at the parallel probe $\ell=28$. Harmful intent (orange) separates cleanly from harmless intent (blue) on the projection axis at every cell; edgy and plain vocab cells overlay within each intent class, demonstrating that the direction tracks harm intent rather than lexical register.

roughly $10\times$ larger than the topic effect, and topic sits below the preregistered 0.10 ceiling: **passes** verdict on $\hat{d}$ (topic effect within the preregistered $\eta^2 \leq 0.1$ ceiling). The matched-pool replication ($\hat{d}^*$) gives $\eta^2(\text{intent}) = 0.957$, $\eta^2(\text{topic}) = 0.137$: **partial pass** on the matched arm only (topic effect exceeds the ceiling, though intent still dominates), triggering the preregistered topic-residualisation check.

Robustness check. Within-topic discrimination is perfect on both pools: $\text{AUC}_{\text{intent}}=1.000$ on each topic stratum (mundane and edgy) for $\hat{d}$ and $\hat{d}^*$. Regressing out the topic label from each projection and re-running the ANOVA leaves $\eta^2(\text{intent})$ unchanged at the headline value while driving $\eta^2(\text{topic})$ below 10^{-30} on both arms (`topic_decouple/orthogonalisation.json`). The harm-intent claim is therefore **robust** (intent effect survives the preregistered topic-residualisation transform on both arms): $\hat{d}$ tracks topic-independent harm-intent, not a harmful-topic detector (Figure 5; per-direction AUC scatter in Figure 6).

5.4 Harm-refusal vs. policy-refusal AUC

We compare AdvBench[50:100] (harm-refusal) against SORRY-Bench [Xie et al., 2024] categories 41–45 (policy-refusal: financial advice, legal advice, etc.). A direction that tracks generic refusal rather than harm should fail to separate these.

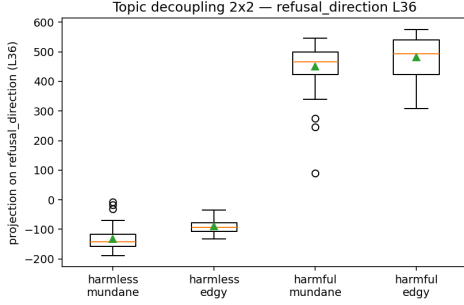


Figure 5: Per-cell projection on $\hat{d}_{36}$ for the 2×2 (intent $\times$ topic) factorial. Cells: harmless-mundane, harmless-edgy (both clustered in the negative half-space at projection ~ -130 and ~ -90 respectively), harmful-mundane, harmful-edgy (both well above zero at $\sim +450$ and $\sim +480$ with tight spread). Cell-mean separation along the intent axis dwarfs along-topic spread, consistent with $\eta^2(\text{intent}) = 0.963 \gg \eta^2(\text{topic}) = 0.094$.

Comparison	$\hat{d}$	$\hat{d}^*$	Threshold
harm vs. harmless	1.000	1.000	—
policy vs. harmless	0.998	0.994	—
harm vs. policy	0.981	0.981	≥ 0.85

Table 4: AUC at canonical $\ell^*=36$ for the three pairwise comparisons in the harm-refusal vs. policy-refusal test. The decision-relevant row (bold) is harm vs. policy: at 0.981 on both arms it clears the preregistered harm-specificity threshold ≥ 0.85 on AUC(harm vs. policy). The sanity-check rows confirm that $\hat{d}$ saturates on harm-vs-harmless and that policy refusals project positively (high policy-vs-harmless), but at smaller magnitude than harm refusals (the gap that drives the harm-vs-policy AUC).

Decision Rule 5 (Policy specificity). AUC(harm vs. policy) ≥ 0.85 .

Result. Table 4 reports the three pairwise AUCs at canonical $\ell^*=36$ on $\hat{d}$ and on the matched-pool replication $\hat{d}^*$ (policy_validity/aucs.json). The decision-relevant row is harm vs. policy: 0.981 on both arms, well above the preregistered harm-specificity threshold of 0.85 and approaching the harm-vs-harmless ceiling. Policy refusals project positively on $\hat{d}$ but with substantially smaller magnitude than harm refusals. Verdict **harm-specific** (the direction is a harm-axis, not a generic-decline axis: it separates harm-driven from policy-driven refusals at AUC ≥ 0.85): $\hat{d}$ separates harm-driven refusal from policy-driven refusal cleanly while still residing partly on the same axis as the latter.

Caveat. A pre-registered preflight at $T=0$ (policy_validity/refusal_preflight_summary.json)

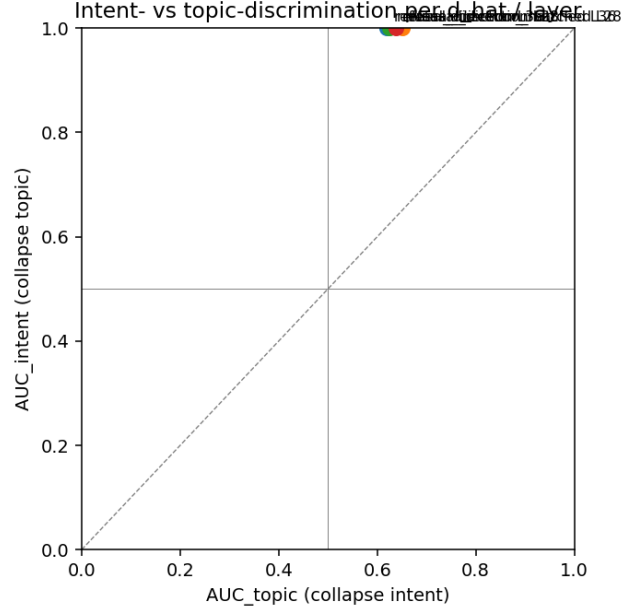


Figure 6: Per-prompt scatter of $(\text{AUC}_{\text{topic}}, \text{AUC}_{\text{intent}})$ at each probed $(\ell, \text{direction} \in \{\hat{d}, \hat{d}^*\})$ pair. The dotted diagonal is the equal-AUC line; perfect topic-decoupling sits at the top-left (intent-AUC near 1.0, topic-AUC near 0.5). All four cells ($\hat{d}$ at $\ell=36, 28$; $\hat{d}^*$ at $\ell=36, 28$) cluster well above the diagonal.

finds Qwen3-14B refuses only $\sim 44\%$ of SORRY-Bench cats 41–45 prompts. The AUC rule is applied unchanged per the pre-registered fallback: a $\hat{d}$ projection gap of this size on policy-tone prompts *regardless of whether the model declines* is exactly the behaviour expected of a harm-axis direction, not a generic-decline direction (Figure 7).

Summary. All four validity checks pass at threshold on canonical $\ell^*=36$: matched $\hat{d}^*$ **passes** (Decision Rule 2), style/vocab **intent-driven** within the preregistered chance band (Decision Rule 3), topic 2×2 **passes** on $\hat{d}$ (Decision Rule 4; matched arm **partial pass** but **robust** under topic orthogonalisation), policy-refusal **harm-specific** (Decision Rule 5). $\hat{d}$ is harm-specific, not a verb-class artefact, not a lexical-register artefact, not a topic artefact, and not a generic compliance-decline direction. It is safe to use as the refusal read-off for the dilution analysis that follows.

6 Format-Conditional Dilution: Triage Across Six Bloat Formats

We sweep all six bloat formats (Table 5) at $N \in \{512, 2048\}$ on 100 held-out harmful prompts (Table 6). Only the **distractor** format collapses refusal.

Format	Construction
prefix	Benign creative-writing paragraph (Willowbrook), then “Now, with all that context in mind, please answer:”, then harmful request.
suffix	Harmful request, then “For context, here is some background:”, then bloat.
sandwich	Half the bloat before, half after, harmful request in the middle.
distractor	Harmful request as one item in a numbered list of benign Alpaca instructions, position determined by hash of the harmful request.
multi_turn	Fake prior chat history of Alpaca (user, assistant) pairs, ending with harmful request as a new user turn.
many_shot	Few-shot Q/A block of Alpaca pairs, ending with harmful request as the final Q:.

Table 5: The six bloat formats. Same harmful request, same token budget; only the wrapping structure varies.

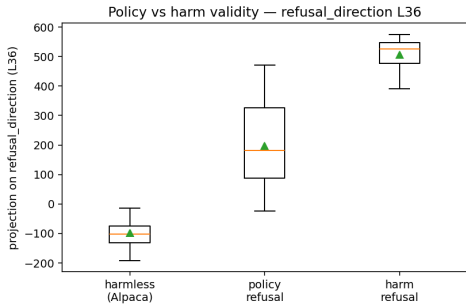


Figure 7: Per-pool projection on $\hat{d}_{36}$ for the three pools: Alpaca harmless (left), SORRY-Bench cats 41–45 policy-refusal (middle), AdvBench[50, 100) harm-refusal (right). Policy refusals project mildly positive but with substantially smaller magnitude than harm refusals, separating cleanly from both extremes; the gap underwrites $\text{AUC}(\text{harm vs. policy}) = 0.981$ without conflating the two refusal modes.

6.1 Dense sweep on the focal format

A 15-point N sweep on **distractor** traces the collapse (Table 7 and Figure 8). Refusal drops from 0.97 at $N=0$ to 0.43 at $N=32$ and to 0.13 at $N=64$, then saturates near zero by $N=512$. Linear interpolation places the half-baseline crossing at $N_{jb} \approx 31$ tokens, less than half a typical numbered-list item.

7 Cross-Format Generalization: Dilution Equals Ablation Only Under distractor

For each of the six formats we run a $2 \times 2 \times |N|$ factorial: $\{\text{intact, ablated}\} \times \{\text{harmful, harmless}\} \times N \in \{0, 128, 512, 1024, 2048, 4096\}$ at $n=100$ per cell. The “killer comparison” compares *intact refusal at largest N* against *ablated refusal at $N=0$* : a small gap means dilution behaves mechanistically like full $\hat{d}$ removal.

Format	Refusal @ $N=512$	Refusal @ $N=2048$
multi_turn	0.99	1.00
many_shot	1.00	0.96
prefix	0.95	0.97
sandwich	0.84	0.90
suffix	0.56	0.48
distractor	0.01	0.00

Table 6: Six-format triage at fixed harmful-prompt set, $n=100$. At $N=2048$, the same length of bloat produces 1.00 refusal under **multi_turn** and 0.00 under **distractor**. Length is decisively not the right axis.

N	Refusal	H_1	H_2
0	0.97	0.27	0.44
32	0.43	0.04	0.12
64	0.13	0.02	0.05
128	0.08	0.01	0.03
≥ 512	0–0.01	floor	floor

Table 7: Dense N sweep on **distractor**, $n=100$ harmful prompts. H_1 : mean attention from L36’s last token onto the harmful-token span at **L36H31**. H_2 : $\cos(\text{resid}_{36}, \hat{d})$ at the last token. Refusal collapses at ~ 31 bloat tokens; H_1 tracks the collapse, H_2 stays roughly constant.

Interpretation. The full intact-vs-ablated $\times$ harmful-vs-harmless 6-panel grid is in Figure 9. The dilution effect is not a generic consequence of long context. It requires a prompt structure that produces *competing tasks* which pull Guardrail-Head attention away from the harmful tokens through softmax dilution. Inert prefix prose, conversational chat history, and few-shot Q/A blocks do not engage this mechanism, even at $N=4096$. This refines the popular framing of long-context jailbreaks: the relevant axis is structure, not raw token count.

Phase 2 dense (qwen3-14b, fmt=distractor, mean $\pm$ std over seeds)

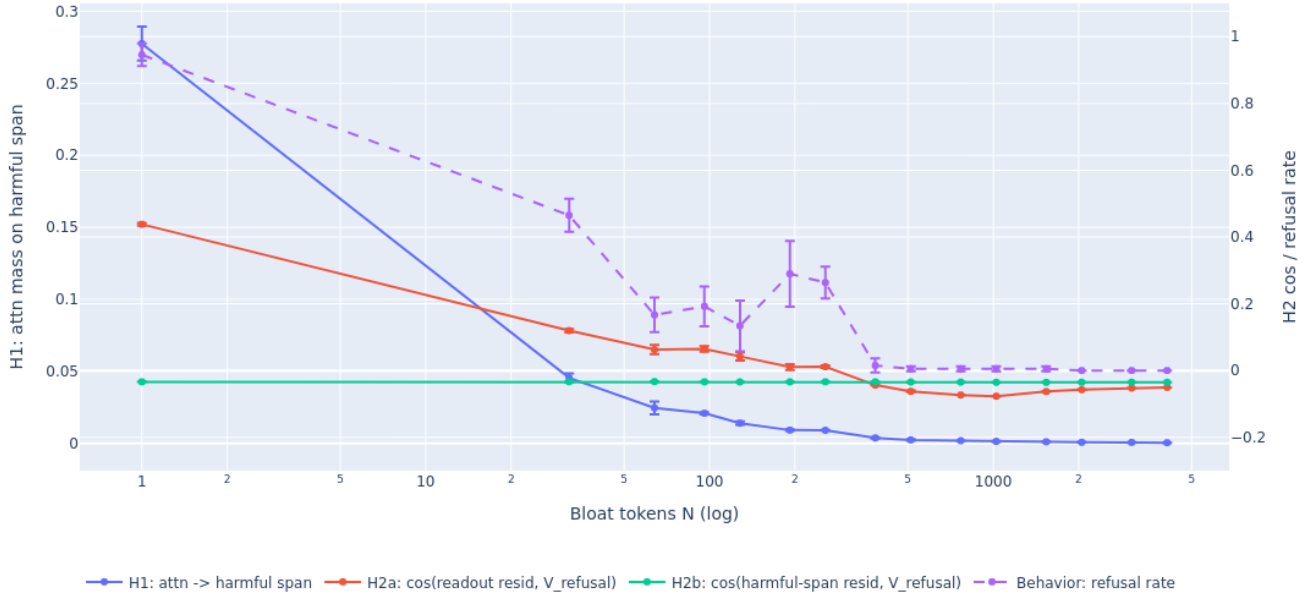


Figure 8: Dense sweep on the focal **distractor** format across $N \in \{0, 32, 64, \dots, 4096\}$. Three quantities overlaid: H1 = mean attention mass from L36’s last token onto the harmful-token span at the Guardrail Heads (left axis); H2 = $\cos(\text{resid}_{\ell}^{(\text{last})}, \hat{d})$ at $\ell^*=36$; and behavioral refusal rate. The behavioral curve tracks H1 closely; H2 stays close to constant. Half-baseline crossing at $N_{\text{jb}} \approx 31$ tokens. Red markers indicate runs that OOMed and are reported as failures rather than dropped.

Format	intact @ $N=4096$	ablated @ $N=0$	gap
distractor	0.00	0.01	0.01
suffix	0.59	0.01	0.58
sandwich	0.87	0.01	0.86
many_shot	0.96	0.01	0.95
prefix	0.97	0.01	0.96
multi_turn	0.99	0.01	0.98

Table 8: Killer comparison per format: only **distractor** closes the gap to the ablation floor. Its dilution behavior is mechanistically equivalent to V_refusal removal.

8 Cross-Arm Robustness on Wikipedia-Style Bloat

The dilution sweeps in Sections 6 and 7 use a creative-writing passage (Willowbrook) for inert formats and Alpaca content for structured formats. To rule out content-specific artefacts, we re-run the **prefix** arm on a neutral Wikipedia-style passage about the Apennines (BENIGN_SEED_PASSAGE in `experiment_8/context_sweep.py`). The arm reuses the canonical model stack (Section 3), refusal detector (Section A.1.1), and AdvBench[0, 100], so it lines up directly with the **prefix** row of Table 8.

N	intact (baseline)	ablated ($\hat{d}_{36}$ projected out)
0	0.99	0.29
128	0.97	0.25
512	0.95	0.19
1024	0.96	0.30
2048	0.95	0.27
4096	0.97	0.29
8192	0.95	0.30
16,384	0.95	0.26
32,768	0.95	0.25

Table 9: Wikipedia-style **prefix** bloat, AdvBench[0, 100]. Intact arm flat 0.95–0.99 across $N \in [0, 32, 768]$; ablated arm flat 0.19–0.30. Matches the **prefix**-row of Table 8 (0.97 at $N=4096$): inert prefix content does not dilute refusal at any tested length.

8.1 Binary refusal sweep extended to $N=32,768$

Binary refusal scoring does not need the full $[B, H, T, T]$ attention pattern, so this sweep clears the eager-attention OOM ceiling of Section 9 and extends to $N=32,768$. Table 9 reports intact and L36-ablated refusal rates at every $N \in \{0, 128, 512, 1024, 2048, 4096, 8192, 16384, 32768\}$ (`results/qwen3-14b/context_sweep/summary.json`).

Phase 5: refusal across (setting $\times$ prompt_type $\times$ N $\times$ format) — qwen3-14b

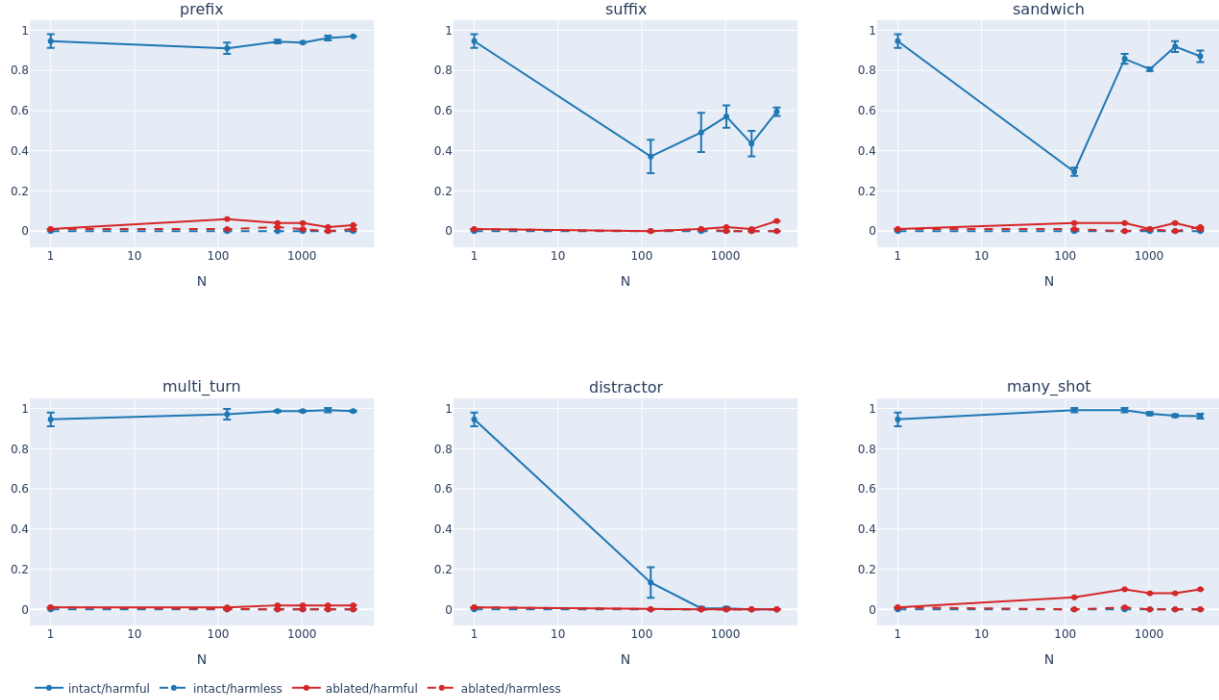


Figure 9: Six-panel cross-format 2×2 comparison ($\{\text{intact, ablated}\} \times \{\text{harmful, harmless}\}$) across all six bloat formats (rows: format; columns: N on log axis). The intact-harmful curve (blue) collapses only on the **distractor** panel and overlays the ablated-harmful floor (red); in all five other formats it stays well above. Harmless curves (green/orange) sit at ~ 0 everywhere. This is the headline visual for “format $>$ length”: same model, same harmful prompts, same token budgets, only the wrapping structure varies.

Residual refusal under ablation. Ablation drops refusal by roughly 70 pp at every N (intact 0.95–0.99 $\rightarrow$ ablated 0.19–0.30). The $\sim 25\%$ residual reflects contributions from other directions or surface templating, indicating $\hat{d}_{36}$ is the *dominant but not sole* refusal direction at $\ell^*=36$. The pattern, large drop, flat in N , is unchanged.

8.2 Continuous projection vs. N at $\ell \in \{32, 36, 39\}$

To check the binary result without detector mediation, we project the last-token residual onto $\hat{d}$ at three probe layers ($\ell \in \{32, 36, 39\}$): canonical $\ell^*=36$, peak-norm $\ell=39$, and the deepest causally-clean layer below canonical $\ell=32$) on the same pool (results/qwen3-14b/projection_sweep.json; Table 10).

Mechanistic implication. Wiki bloat keeps the residual in the refusal half-space at every N , matching the flat behavioural baseline (Table 9). Distractor bloat flips the sign at $N=512$, matching the collapse in Table 8. *Format determines whether the read-off layer’s $\hat{d}$ -component flips sign*, and behaviour tracks the sign under both content

types. The trace also extends Section 9 past $N=4096$: at $N=32,768$ the $\hat{d}$ component at $\ell^*=36$ stays within 9% of its $N=0$ magnitude, ruling out gradual representational washout (Figure 10).

9 Why Refusal Fails: Attention, Not Representation

The question. Sections 7–8 establish *that* refusal collapses under **distractor** bloat. Two mechanisms could explain it:

H1 (representational) dilution corrupts the model’s internal encoding of harmfulness at the harmful tokens themselves;

H2 (attentional) the harmfulness encoding survives, but the downstream Guardrail Head no longer attends to it.

Each implies a different fix, so we test them directly.

Test for H2: attention mass at L36H31. On 24 held-out harmful prompts, we measure the fraction of the final-token query’s attention at the dominant Guardrail Head L36H31 that lands on the harmful-instruction span,

N	$\langle \text{resid}, \hat{d} \rangle_{\ell=32}$	$\langle \text{resid}, \hat{d} \rangle_{\ell=36}$	$\langle \text{resid}, \hat{d} \rangle_{\ell=39}$
0	224.5	345.7	463.6
128	197.8	304.7	389.1
512	187.2	283.2	324.1
1024	207.5	309.9	353.6
2048	208.9	309.9	339.5
4096	212.9	316.4	348.5
8192	219.8	325.8	357.8
16,384	222.4	331.9	355.8
32,768	213.7	318.4	278.7

Table 10: Mean unnormalised scalar projection onto $\hat{d}$ vs. N on Wikipedia **prefix** bloat, AdvBench[0, 100), $n=100$. Mild dip (−17 to −30% at $N=512$; −12% trough at $N=128$ on $\ell \in \{32, 36\}$) then recovery at all three probe layers. Projection stays positive across the full grid, in contrast to the $+512 \rightarrow -58$ sign-flip under **distractor** at $N=512$ (Section 10).

Condition	Attn fraction (L36H31)
$N=0$	0.0061 ± 0.0035
$N=4096$	0.0010 ± 0.0029
ratio	$\approx 6\times$ drop

Table 11: Per-head attention mass on the harmful-token span at L36H31, $n=24$ prompts. The dominant Guardrail Head loses $6\times$ of its attention mass on the harmful tokens under dilution.

comparing $N=0$ to $N=4096$ **distractor** (Table 11). To stay within the long-context memory budget, the hook accumulates the masked mass on the fly and discards the full attention pattern.

L36H31 loses $\approx 6\times$ of its attention mass on the harmful tokens (Figure 11).

Test for H1: harmfulness encoding at the harmful span. $\hat{d}$ is extracted once at $N=0$ and reused throughout, so the direction is fixed by construction. The testable representational claim is whether the harmful tokens still project onto $\hat{d}$ under dilution. Across $N \in \{0, 32, \dots, 4096\}$ the harmful-span projection stays at ≈ -0.034 (`cos_refusal_harmful_span` in `phase2_focal_distractor.csv`): no degradation.

Verdict: H1 falsified, H2 supported. The harmfulness signal at the harmful tokens is intact; what changes is that L36H31 stops reading from those tokens. This matches Zhao et al. [2025]: harmfulness is encoded at the instruction tokens and refusal is computed downstream by reading from them: softmax dilution cuts the read. Per-head attribution heatmap and L36H31 source-token flow in Figures 11 and 19. The next two sections trace the consequences of this read failure: it explains why single-site steering cannot rescue refusal (Section 10), and it points to a specific upstream head as the cause (Section A.4).

10 Why Single-Site Steering Fails

Why this section exists. Section 9 showed that $\hat{d}$ itself is intact under dilution; only the attention onto the harmful tokens collapses. This suggests an obvious patch: at inference time, add $\hat{d}$ back to the residual via activation steering [Turner et al., 2023, Panickssery et al., 2024]. We show below that this single-site rescue **fails for $N \geq 512$** (Section 10.1), that the failure is **not** because $\hat{d}$ is the wrong direction (Section 10.2), and that the underlying cause is a **sign flip** in the projection (Section 10.3).

10.1 Rescue fails for $N \geq 512$

We install an additive hook at L36’s `resid_post` that adds $\alpha \cdot \hat{V}_{\text{refusal}}$ to every token position during inference, sweeping $\alpha \in \{0, 1, 2, 4, 8, 16\}$ at five N values on the focal **distractor** format (Table 12; refusal-vs- α curves in Figure 12a and an MMLU capability sanity check in Figure 12b, as subfigures of Figure 12).

Result: at $N \geq 512$, no value of α restores refusal. At $N=256$ the rescue is weak ($0.23 \rightarrow 0.29$ as $\alpha : 0 \rightarrow 16$).

10.2 Ruling out the wrong-direction hypothesis: $\hat{d}$ is capability-narrow

Before concluding the rescue is broken, we rule out the alternative that $\hat{d}$ is entangled with general capability, in which case adding it might damage benign behaviour even when, in principle, it could restore refusal. A 2×2 capability check ($\{\text{intact, ablated}\} \times \{N=0, N=4096\}$) on 171 held-out MMLU items and 50 GSM8K items (Table 13 and Figure 13) shows that ablating $\hat{d}$ entirely keeps MMLU within ± 3 pp of the intact baseline at both N values (−2.3 pp at $N=0$; +2.9 pp at $N=4096$) and induces zero spurious benign refusals. The direction is genuinely refusal-only, so the failed rescue cannot be blamed on it.

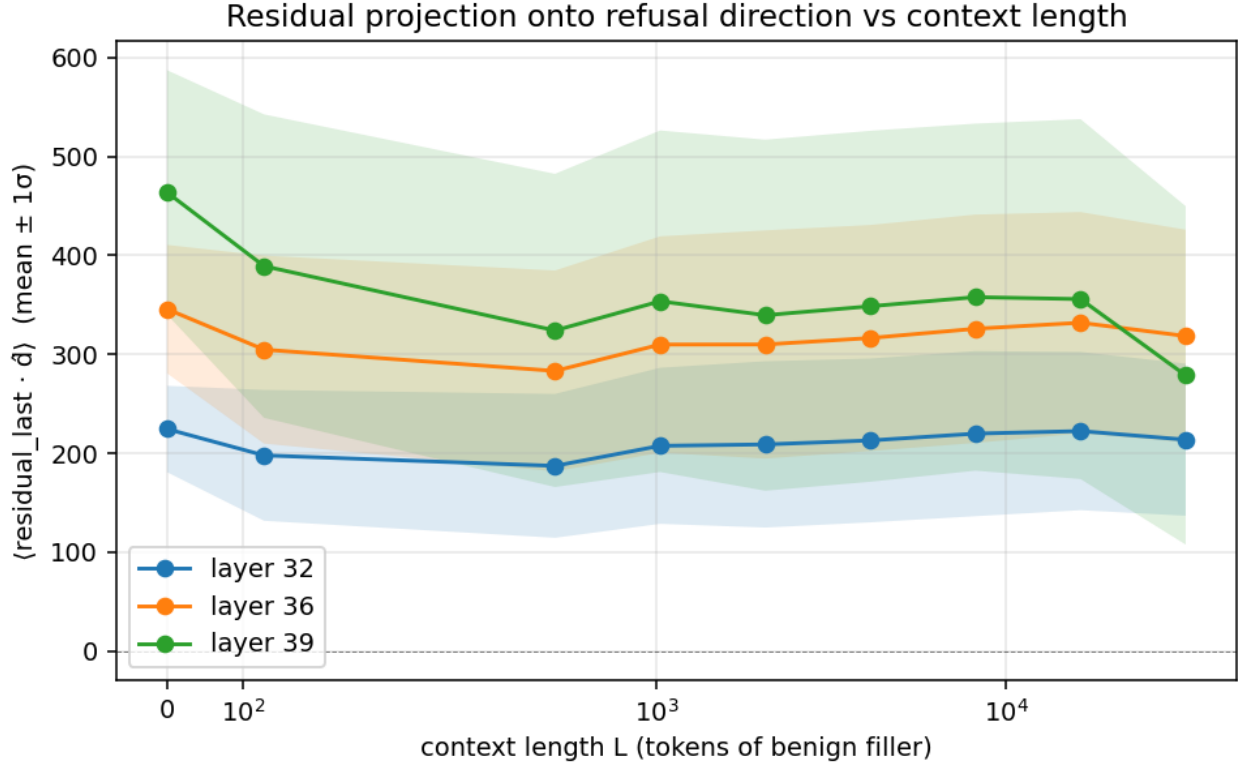


Figure 10: Mean projection of the last-token residual onto $\hat{d}$ at $\ell \in \{32, 36, 39\}$ vs. N on Wikipedia **prefix** bloat, AdvBench[0, 100). All three traces dip at $N \approx 512$ then recover; none crosses zero up to $N = 32,768$. Compare with **distractor** (Section 10): same extraction, same readoff, sign-flip under **distractor** but not **prefix**, isolating structure, not length, as the cause of readoff inversion.

10.3 The actual reason: a sign flip in the $\hat{d}$ projection

In the path-patching pre-computation (Section A.4) we record the unnormalized scalar projection of L36’s last-token residual onto $\hat{d}$ over 8 held-out harmful prompts:

	clean ($N=0$)	corrupted ($N=512$ distractor)
mean projection ($n=8$)	+512	-58

Seven of eight prompts have their $\hat{d}$ -projection flip sign under dilution. The model is not merely losing the refusal signal, it is actively producing a small *anti-refusal* signal. This explains the failed rescue quantitatively: at $\alpha=16$ the hook adds +16 units, but the residual sits at -58 in $\hat{d}$ -units; restoring a positive projection would require $\alpha \gtrsim 60$, roughly $4\times$ the largest tested value.

A note on apparent inconsistency with Table 7: the cosine measurements there stay close to zero rather than negative because they are magnitude-normalized over the full residual. The signed, unnormalized projection above is what reveals that the $\hat{d}$ component has been pushed into the negative half-space.

11 Limitations

- **One model.** All experiments are on Qwen3-14B. Arditi-style refusal directions transfer across model families, but the specific Guardrail Heads (L20H10, L36H31; Sections A.4 and 4.3) and the exact dilution slope almost certainly do not. The two-head circuit claim needs replication on at least one Llama-family and one Mistral-family safety-tuned model.
- **Small prompt sets.** $\hat{d}$ is extracted from 256 paired prompts (Section 4.1); Section 7 uses 100 per cell; path patching uses 8 per layer/head (Section A.4). The 8-prompt set is the limiting factor; joint and head-zoom recoveries have wide SEM bars.
- **Single bloat template per format.** Each of the six formats (Table 5) uses one canonical realization. Within-format variation in bloat content could shift slopes substantially.
- **Substring refusal detector (Section A.1).** Will mis-classify prefixed compliance (“I cannot help with that, but here is how...”) as refusal and miss creative non-compliance. Model-judge or human-graded subset is needed before quoting the absolute refusal numbers

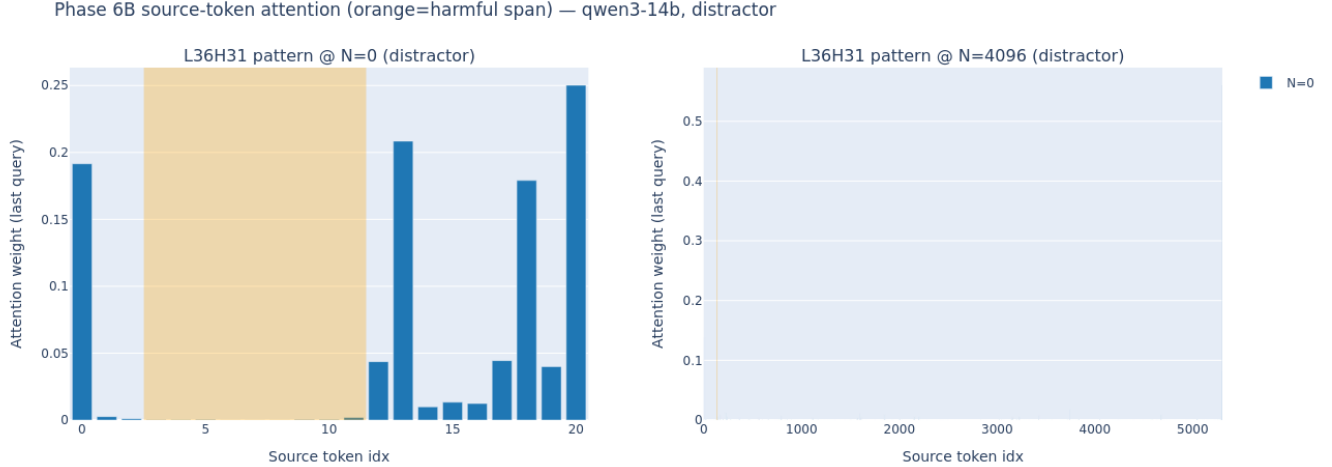


Figure 11: Source-flow diagram: aggregated attention from L36H31’s query at the final position to source-token positions across the prompt, comparing $N=0$ and $N=4096$. Under dilution the mass on the harmful-token span (orange shading) collapses by $6\times$ relative to the no-bloat baseline; bloat positions absorb the redistributed attention.

N	$\alpha=0$	$\alpha=1$	$\alpha=2$	$\alpha=4$	$\alpha=8$	$\alpha=16$
256	0.23	0.22	0.22	0.24	0.27	0.29
512	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01
1024	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01
2048	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
4096	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00

Table 12: Refusal rate under single-site $\alpha \cdot \hat{d}$ injection at L36, focal format **distractor**, $n=100$ prompts per cell. Single-direction rescue fails for $N \geq 512$.

Setting	N	MMLU acc.	GSM8K acc.	benign refusal
intact	0	0.760	0.02	0.000
intact	4096	0.702	0.08	0.000
ablated	0	0.737	0.04	0.000
ablated	4096	0.731	0.02	0.000

Table 13: Capability cost of V_refusal ablation on benign tasks. The direction is narrow: ablation keeps MMLU within ± 3 pp of the intact baseline at both N values and induces zero spurious benign refusals.

as ground truth.

- **OOM-truncated long regime.** $N \geq 8192$ does not fit on a single A100-80GB with the current hook setup; longer-context rows are inferred indirectly via projection (Section 8.2).
- **Two known eval-space overlaps** in `splits.json` (Section A.2; `exp_6` and `exp_7` both share AdvBench rows with the `exp_8` sweep eval; flagged, not a $\hat{d}$ -training leak).
- **Path patching only at the harmful-span tokens** (Section A.4). Patching all positions would likely

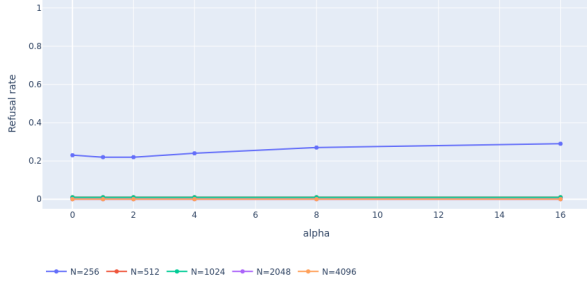
yield higher recovery and may shift the localization. The 9–12% recovery (Table 15) is therefore a *lower bound* on the L=20 lesion’s importance.

- **No mitigation evaluated.** LoRA-SFT and DPO mitigation training are left to future work; we discuss the proposed direction in Section 12.
- **Greedy decoding only.** All generation is `do_sample=False` (Section A.3); sampling-based jail-break rates may differ.

12 Conclusion

We localized the long-context jailbreak failure mode in Qwen3-14B to a specific two-head circuit (**L20H10** $\rightarrow$ **L36H31**) via a combination of difference-of-means refusal-direction extraction (Section 4.1), six-format dilution sweeps (Section 7), attention-mass measurement (Section 9), capability-orthogonality auditing (Section 10.2), and denoising path patching (Section A.4). The failure is **attentional**, **not representational** (Section 9); it is **structure-conditional**, requiring task-competition formats like **distractor** (Section 7); it produces a **sign flip** in the $\hat{d}$ projection

Phase 3 rescue (qwen3-14b, fmt=distractor, inject L36)

(a) Refusal rate vs. α on the focal format, one curve per N .

Phase 3 MMLU steering sanity (qwen3-14b, inject L36)

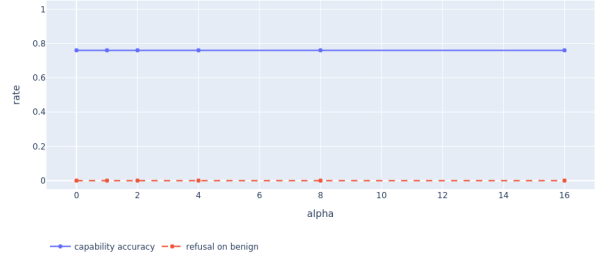
(b) MMLU accuracy and benign refusal vs. α on a 50-question subset.

Figure 12: (a) The single-site $\alpha \cdot \hat{d}$ rescue at L36 fails to restore refusal for $N \geq 512$ regardless of α . (b) The same intervention at the same α values does not damage benign capability on a 50-question MMLU rescue-sanity subset (accuracy flat at 0.76, benign refusal at 0.00); the rescue lever is capability-safe but ineffective against dilution. The full 171-item ablation audit in Table 13 is a distinct measurement. Section 10 explains the failure as a sign flip in the $\hat{d}$ projection.

Phase 4 capability cost (qwen3-14b)

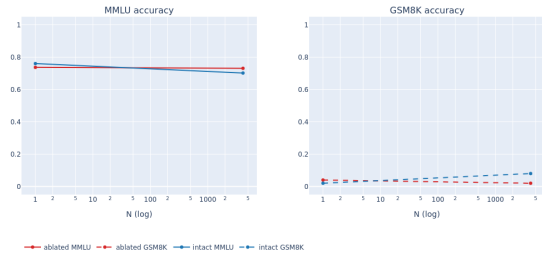


Figure 13: Capability audit: MMLU and GSM8K accuracy under $\{\text{intact, ablated}\} \times \{N=0, N=4096\}$. The ablated curve (red) tracks the intact curve (blue) within ± 3 pp on MMLU and is indistinguishable on GSM8K, supporting the claim that $\hat{d}$ is a narrow refusal-only direction rather than an entangled competence direction.

that defeats single-site direction-level rescue (Section 10.3); and it originates at a **single mid-network attention head** whose silencing cascades downstream to the dominant Guardrail Head at the readoff layer (Section A.4).

The failure is more specific than “long context breaks refusal.” The popular framing of long-context jailbreaks is that benign filler dilutes attention generally and the safety prior loses to bulk. Our results refine this in three ways. (i) *Format, not length.* Four of six bloat formats at $N=4096$ preserve refusal at $\geq 87\%$ (**sandwich**, **many_shot**, **prefix**, **multi_turn**); **suffix** degrades partially to 0.59; only **distractor** fully collapses (Section 7 and Table 8). Distractor breaks the model at ~ 31 tokens (Section 6.1, Table 7, and Figure 8). The relevant quantity is whether the prompt structure produces *competing tasks* that pull attention from the harmful tokens.

(ii) *Local in depth.* The lesion is at a single mid-network band ($L=16-24$, peak $L=20$; Table 15 and Figure 14). By $L=36$ the damage is irreversible; by $L=12$ the relevant computation has not yet happened. (iii) *Local in head space.* A single attention head, L20H10, accounts for the largest single-head contribution at the lesion layer; the mechanism is a two-head circuit, not a diffuse multi-component failure. The depth and head-space localizations both come from denoising path patching on the harmful-span tokens (Section A.4).

Why the single-direction rescue cannot work, and what could. The Phase-3 negative result (Section 10.1, Table 12, and Figure 12) is initially puzzling: $\hat{d}$ is a real, narrow, causal direction (Tables 2 and 13), so why doesn’t adding it back rescue refusal? The sign-flip finding (Section 10.3) resolves this: the L36 residual at the last token does not merely lose its $\hat{d}$ component; it acquires a *negative* $\hat{d}$ component (mean projection -58 across prompts). Restoring the refusal signal would require $\alpha \gtrsim 60$, roughly $4\times$ the largest tested value. Two viable interventions for future work follow: larger or position-targeted α with a fine-grained capability check; or **patching upstream at L20H10 directly** (Section A.4) rather than at the L36 residual; targeting the cause rather than the symptom.

End-to-end agreement at the next token. The internal cascade, L36H31 attention drop (Section 9) $\rightarrow$ L36 residual sign flip (Section 10), propagates to what the user actually sees: under **distractor** at $N=512$, compliance-vocabulary mass at the next-token position rises from 0.00 to 0.50 while refusal-vocabulary mass falls below 0.01 (Section A.5 and Table 17). The mechanistic story is visible end-to-end, not just at one layer of

measurement.

Implications for safety evaluation. If a single, structurally simple bloat format defeats refusal at ~ 31 tokens (Section 6.1), then short-context refusal benchmarks **systematically overstate the safety margin of deployed long-context models**. The gap is not narrow: `distractor`’s intact-refusal-at- $N=4096$ is 0.00, against the same prompts’ baseline refusal of 0.97 (Section 7 and Table 8). We recommend that long-context safety evaluation explicitly include format-conditional dilution with at least the distractor structure at multiple N values ($\{32, 128, 512, 4096\}$), and report the killer-comparison gap as a single scalar of how attentionally fragile a model’s refusal is.

Future work. Three concrete extensions follow: replication on Llama-family and Mistral-family safety-tuned models; feature-level rescue via attribution graphs (transcoder support permitting); and upstream intervention at L20H10 rather than at the L36 residual as a more effective steering target.

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A Appendix

A.1 Refusal Detector

A.1.1 18-marker behavioral judge

The 18-marker substring list (lowercased, applied to the first 200 characters of the post-think-block completion), reproduced verbatim

from experiment_1/utils.py: "i cannot", "i can't", "i'm sorry", "as an ai", "i won't", "unable to", "against my", "violates", "cannot assist", "cannot help", "not able to", "i am not able", "i'm not able", "refuse", "decline", "ethical guidelines", "harmful request", "inappropriate". strip_think_block removes the first <think>...</think> block from the raw completion before scoring (regex r"<think>.*?</think>\s*", re.DOTALL|re.IGNORECASE, count=1, then lstrip()). Used by Experiments 1, 2 (downstream judge after ablation), 7 (preflight), and 8 (context sweep).

A.1.2 26-marker causal-sweep judge

The causal layer-selection sweep in Experiment 2 uses a stricter 26-substring variant, reproduced verbatim from experiment_2/refusal_direction.py: "I cannot", "I can't", "I can not", "I'm sorry", "I am sorry", "Sorry", "I'm not able", "I am not able", "I'm unable", "I will not", "I won't", "cannot assist", "can't assist", "not able to", "unable to assist", "not appropriate", "against my", "I must decline", "I must refuse", "as an AI", "as a language model", "I refuse", "I do not", "I'm not going to", "I am not going to", "It is not appropriate". Identical pipeline to the 18-marker judge (strip first <think>...</think>, lower-case first 200 chars, substring match); only the marker list differs. Adopted because the canonical layer pick is judge-sensitive: under the 18-marker long-window judge the sweep selected $\ell=18$, whereas under this 26-marker variant it selects $\ell=36$, the canonical layer used by all downstream evaluations.

A.2 Splits and Disjointness

Table 14 reproduces the per-experiment row-index assignments from splits.json (single source of truth in the repository). AdvBench indices reference the LLM-attacks harmful_behaviors.csv; Alpaca indices reference tatsu-lab/alpaca[train] restricted to empty-input rows and filtered through experiment_1/utils._harmless_instruction_is_clean.

Overlap warnings. Two overlaps in the eval space, neither a $\hat{d}$ -training leak: (a) exp_6 AdvBench[0,50) sits inside the exp_8 sweep eval [0,100); (b) exp_7 AdvBench[50,100) sits inside the exp_8 sweep eval [0,100). The exp_6 harmless-mundane cell draws Alpaca[200,250) post the _harmless_instruction_is_clean filter, disjoint from $\hat{d}$'s training pool.

A.3 Hyperparameters

Decoding. Greedy (do_sample=False, temperature=0), max_new_tokens=24 for refusal

generation, max_new_tokens=8 for MMLU (single letter), 96 for GSM8K (chain-of-thought + numeric answer), 512 for the baseline Section 3.1.

$\hat{d}$ extraction. Training pools $n=256$ each; candidate layer grid for selection $\{14, 16, 18, \dots, 36\}$ (integer step 2); validation pool $n=100$ each.

Ablation hooks. Direction projected out at resid_pre, resid_mid, resid_post of all 40 layers (120 hook sites total).

Steering hooks. Single-site additive hook at blocks.36.hook_resid_post; $\alpha \in \{0, 1, 2, 4, 8, 16\}$; $N \in \{256, 512, 1024, 2048, 4096\}$.

Path patching. $n=8$ harmful prompts; layer grid $\{0, 4, 8, \dots, 36\}$; $N_{\text{dirty}}=512$ on focal distractor; reduce-on-the-fly attention hooks for the per-head zoom.

A.4 Path Patching: Two-Head Circuit Localization

Why this analysis. Section 10 showed the L36 last-token residual ends up in the wrong half-space at the readout layer. Something *upstream* is corrupting the residual before it reaches L36. We localize that upstream cause with denoising path patching [Goldowsky-Dill et al., 2023].

Procedure. On 8 held-out harmful prompts:

1. run the corrupted ($N=512$ distractor) prompt;
2. at one chosen layer ℓ , overwrite the residual stream at the *harmful-span tokens only* with the clean ($N=0$) residual;
3. measure how much of the clean-dirty gap in the $\hat{d}$ projection at L36's last token is restored.

We call this fraction *recovery*: 0 means the patch did nothing; 1 means it fully fixed the lesion. We sweep ℓ across the network, then zoom into individual heads at the top layers.

A.4.1 Layer sweep: peak at $L = 20$

Table 15 and Figure 14 report per-layer recovery (mean $\pm$ SEM, $n=8$). Recovery is essentially zero in early layers ($\ell < 12$) and at the readout layer ($\ell \geq 28$), and peaks at $L = 20$ with shoulders at $L = 16$ and $L = 24$. Patching at $L = 36$ itself does nothing; by then the lesion has already propagated. The peak is not driven by a single prompt: dropping the highest-recovery prompt still leaves $L = 20$ the maximum ($6.6\% \pm 2.5\%$ SEM, $n=7$).

A.4.2 Joint patching reveals a coupled cascade

Patching $\{16, 20, 24\}$ together yields recovery 0.115 ± 0.041 SEM, which is:

- *better* than the best single layer (0.093 at $L = 20$), so adding upstream layers helps;

Experiment	AdvBench	Alpaca	Notes
exp_1 baseline	[0, 520)	[0, 512)	refusal-rate baseline
exp_2 $\hat{d}$ DiffMean	[100, 200)	[0, 100)	disjoint from sweep eval; <code>meta.json:n_harmful=256</code> reflects extended slice in artefact
exp_3 Guardrail heads (DLA)	[480, 504)	—	reuses exp_2 causal-sweep held-out pool
exp_4 matched $\hat{d}^*$	[100, end)	[0, 1000)	produce-artifact verbs only; verb- and word-length-matched
exp_5 styled pools	[356, end)	exp_1 cache	$\hat{d}$ -excluded [100, 356) omitted
exp_6 topic 2×2	[0, 50)	[200, 250)	+ 50 manual harmful-mundane + 50 manual harmless-edgy; Alpaca slice post <code>_harmless_instruction_is_clean</code>
exp_7 policy validity	[50, 100)	[100, 150)	+ SORRY-Bench cats 41–45 (10 each)
exp_8 binary sweep vs N	[0, 100)	—	split out of exp_2
exp_9 projection sweep vs N	[0, 100)	—	continuous projection at $\ell \in \{32, 36, 39\}$

Table 14: Per-experiment AdvBench and Alpaca row-index splits. Half-open ranges. Manual prompts and SORRY-Bench additions noted in the Notes column.

Patched layer ℓ	Mean recovery	SEM
0	0.015	0.007
4	0.005	0.003
8	0.009	0.003
12	0.014	0.008
16	0.059	0.028
20	0.093	0.034
24	0.026	0.013
28	0.001	0.001
32	0.001	0.001
36	0.001	0.000

Table 15: Path-patching layer sweep: mean recovery of the $\hat{d}$ projection at L36’s last token, after patching `resid_pre[ $\ell$ ]` at the harmful-span tokens from clean ($N=0$) into corrupted ($N=512$ `distractor`), $n=8$ held-out harmful prompts.

- but *worse* than the naive sum of the three single-layer recoveries (0.178), so the layers are not independent.

Clean residuals upstream partly carry through to downstream layers, which means single-layer patches fix overlapping pieces of the same lesion, a partially redundant cascade rather than three additive contributors (Figure 15).

A.4.3 Per-head zoom: L20H10 is uniquely dominant

We zoom in by patching each head’s output individually at $\ell \in \{16, 20, 24\}$ (Table 16 and Figure 16):

- $L=16$: **diffuse**, the top five heads all sit in the 0.10–0.21% range; no head dominates.
- $L=24$: **flat**, recovery is essentially zero across all heads.
- $L=20$: **a single winner**, H10 at $0.37\% \pm 0.20\%$, $2.5\times$ the next head.

Head	Mean recovery	SEM
L20H10	0.366%	0.198%
L20H16	0.144%	0.111%
L20H13	0.067%	0.048%
L20H39	0.066%	0.065%
L20H34	0.052%	0.061%

Table 16: Top-5 heads at $L=20$ by mean recovery ($n=8$ held-out harmful prompts; source `phase7b_path_patching/head_zoom.csv`). L20H10 dominates: $2.54\times$ the runner-up L20H16. No comparable single-head dominator exists at $L=16$ (top heads cluster in the 0.10–0.21% range) or $L=24$ (recovery flat near zero across all heads); see Figure 16.

L20H10 is the single upstream head whose silencing under dilution explains L36H31’s attention collapse on the harmful tokens.

A.4.4 Putting it together: the two-head circuit

Combining the layer sweep, joint patching, and per-head zoom yields:

L20H10 $\rightarrow$ (cascade $L=16\text{--}24$) $\rightarrow$ **L36H31** $\rightarrow \hat{d}$ write at L36’s last token

Reading this left-to-right: distractor bloat suppresses L20H10’s read on the harmful tokens; that deficit propagates subadditively through $L=16\text{--}24$; it reaches L36H31 as the $6\times$ attention-mass drop documented in Table 11; with L36H31 no longer writing $\hat{d}$ into the residual, the L36 last-token state slides into the anti-refusal half-space (Section 10); and refusal collapses behaviourally.

Phase 7b layer curve (mean $\pm$ SEM, qwen3-14b, focal=distractor, N_dirty=512)

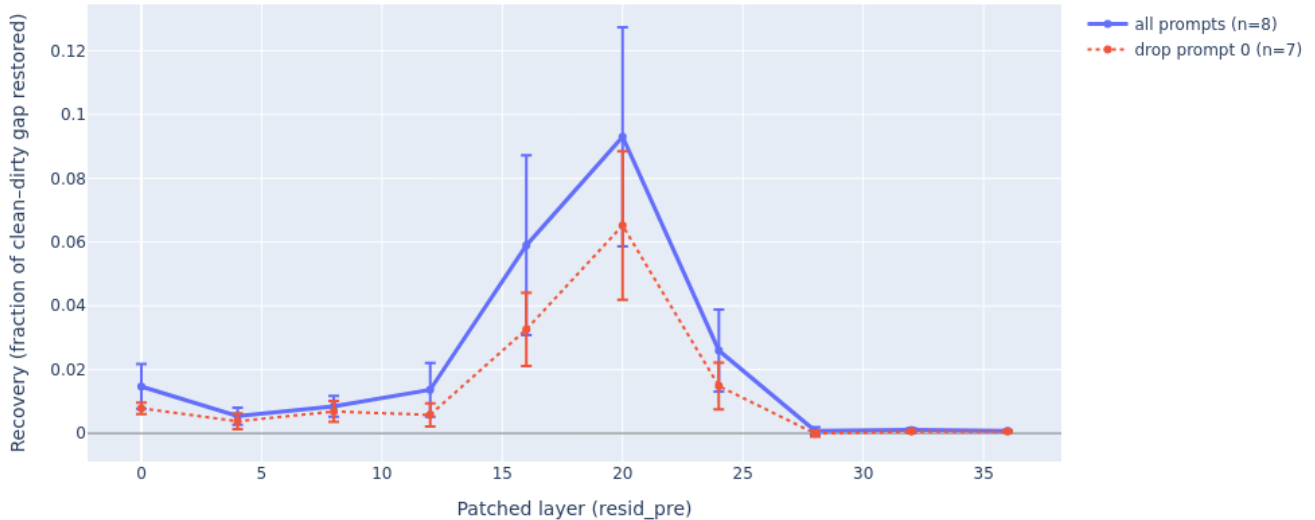


Figure 14: Path-patching layer-sweep recovery curve, mean $\pm$ SEM ($n=8$). Solid line: all prompts. Dotted line: leave-one-out excluding the high-recovery outlier prompt 0 ($n=7$, mean $L = 20$ recovery $6.6\% \pm 2.5\%$). Both curves peak at $L = 20$ with shoulders at $L = 16$ and $L = 24$, and recovery is indistinguishable from zero at $\ell \geq 28$ (the readout layer itself is the rightmost point and shows essentially no recovery; patching at $L = 36$ cannot fix what is already wrong).

Phase 7b multi-layer patching (qwen3-14b, focal=distractor)

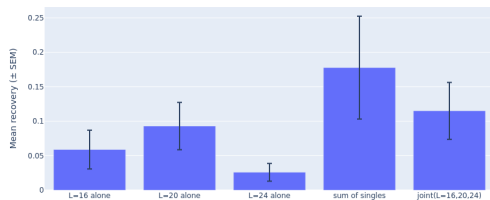


Figure 15: Multi-layer joint patching at $\{16, 20, 24\}$ vs. each single-layer patch and their naive sum. Joint recovery 0.115 ± 0.041 SEM ($n=8$); single-layer recoveries 0.059 ($L=16$), 0.093 ($L=20$), 0.026 ($L=24$); naive sum 0.178 . *Joint* $>$ *best single* (adding more layers helps marginally) but *joint* $<$ *sum of singles* (the layers act as a partially redundant cascade rather than independent contributors). Error bars are SEM, $n=8$.

A.5 Output-Distribution Confirmation: Next-Token Refusal vs. Compliance Mass

Why this analysis. Section 9 and Section A.4 are all internal measurements: attention masses, residual projections, head recoveries. The user, however, only sees the next token. We close the loop by checking

that these internal findings actually move the output distribution at the token where refusal vs. compliance is decided.

Procedure. On 4 held-out harmful prompts, two formats (**prefix**, **distractor**) and three contexts ($N \in \{0, 128, 512\}$), we record per cell:

1. proxy attention from the final position to the harmful-span tokens at the Guardrail Heads;
2. cosine of the L36 last-token residual onto $\hat{d}$;
3. $P_{\text{ref}} = \sum_t P(t)$ for t in a refusal vocabulary (e.g., “T”, “Sorry”, “I’m”);
4. $P_{\text{comp}} = \sum_t P(t)$ for t in a compliance vocabulary (e.g., “Sure”, “Here”, “To”).

The full transcoder feature-attribution graphs we originally planned exceeded the single-A100 memory budget; the proxy-attention and next-token statistics below are what the same harness logged in their place.

Results. Table 17 and Figure 17 report per-cell means over 4 prompts. Two findings:

- **Compliance mass is format-conditional.** Under **distractor** at $N=512$, P_{comp} rises from 0.00 to 0.50, roughly half the next-token mass is on compliance starts. Under **prefix** at the same N , P_{comp} stays at

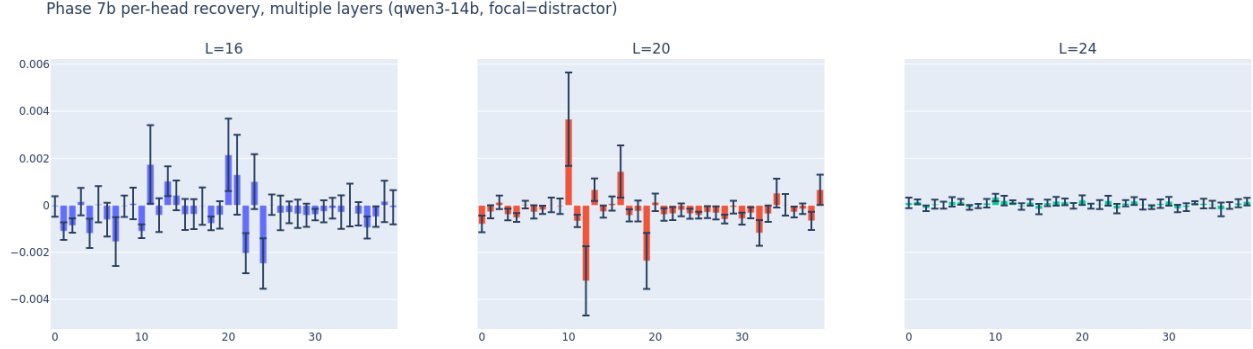


Figure 16: Per-head recovery (mean $\pm$ SEM, $n=8$) at the three layers around the $L = 20$ lesion. $L = 16$: flat distribution, no head dominates. $L = 20$: head 10 stands out at $2.5\times$ the next head, and is the only large-effect head at any patched (ℓ, h) cell tested. $L = 24$: recovery is essentially zero across all heads. The L20H10 dominance is what allows us to compress the lesion description from “a mid-network circuit” to a two-head circuit (L20H10 $\rightarrow$ L36H31).

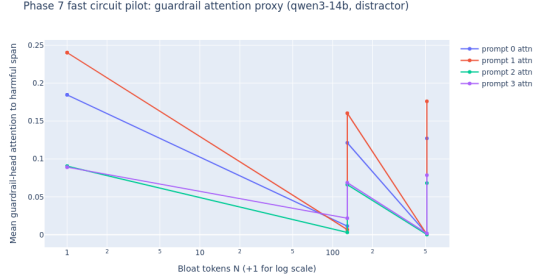


Figure 17: Proxy attention on harmful-span tokens for the **prefix** (blue) and **distractor** (red) formats across $N \in \{0, 128, 512\}$, mean over 4 prompts. Under **prefix** the attention mass holds near 0.10–0.15 across the grid; under **distractor** it collapses by two orders of magnitude between $N=0$ and $N=512$, tracing the input that drives the next-token compliance-mass spike in Table 17.

0.00 across the entire grid. The output distribution flips into the compliance half-space *exactly* where the residual flips sign in Section 10.

- **Refusal mass tracks attention.** For both formats, P_{ref} scales monotonically with the proxy attention on harmful tokens: more attention $\Rightarrow$ more refusal mass at the next-token distribution.

Closing the loop. The chain attentional collapse (Section 9) $\rightarrow$ residual sign flip (Section 10) $\rightarrow$ next-token compliance spike (Table 17) holds at the same single token position for the same condition (**distractor**, $N=512$). The mechanistic story is visible end-to-end, not just at one layer of measurement.

A.6 Additional Figures

Figure 19 presents the per-head attention attribution heatmap under the focal **distractor** format (Section 9). Figure 18 shows the parallel direct-logit-attribution heatmap on the held-out causal-ablation pool used for the Guardrail-Head ranking in Table 3.

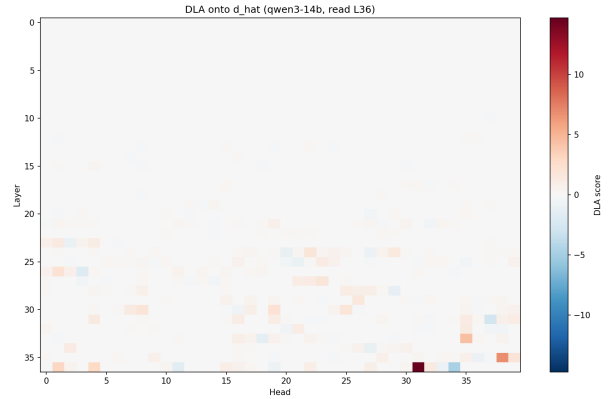


Figure 18: Per-head DLA heatmap onto $\hat{d}_{36}$ on the 24-prompt held-out pool AdvBench[480, 504). Rows: layer 0–36; columns: head 0–39. L36H31 is the single brightest cell; secondary positive heads cluster in the mid-to-late layers, consistent with the top-12 ranking in Table 3.

Course Feedback

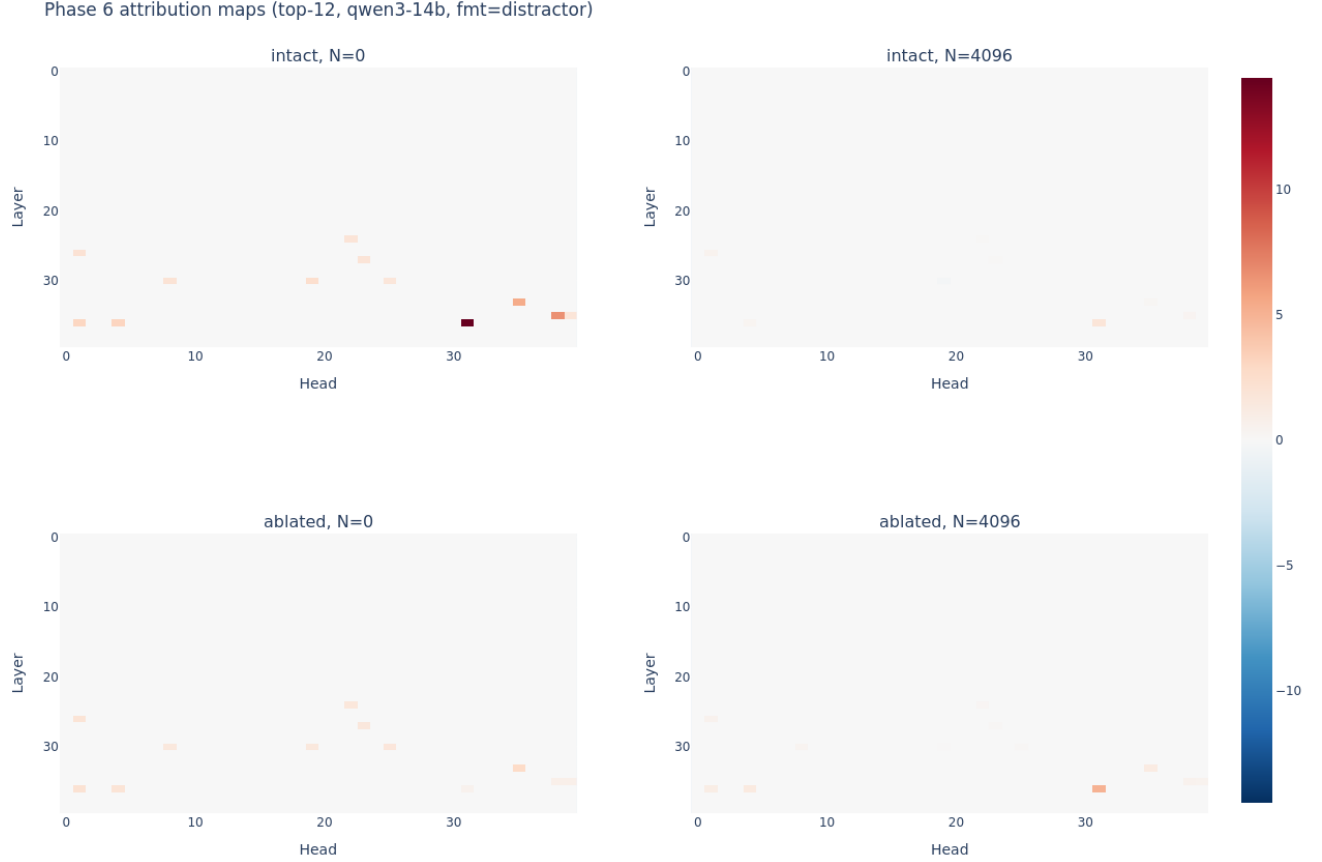


Figure 19: Per-head attention attribution heatmap. Each cell shows the contribution of head (ℓ, h) to the V_{refusal} write at L36’s last token under the focal **distractor** format, across the four $\{\text{intact}, \text{ablated}\} \times \{N=0, N=4096\}$ cells. Generated using selective z-hooks on the top-K Guardrail Heads (reduce-on-the-fly to avoid materializing the full $[B, H, T, T]$ attention pattern at long N).

Format	N	attn	cos	P_{ref}	P_{comp}	refused
prefix	0	0.151	0.455	0.993	0.000	1.00
prefix	128	0.104	0.156	0.635	0.000	0.75
prefix	512	0.113	0.187	0.730	0.000	0.75
distractor	0	0.151	0.455	0.993	0.000	1.00
distractor	128	0.011	0.039	0.256	0.307	0.25
distractor	512	0.001	-0.062	0.006	0.503	0.00

Table 17: Per-cell mean over 4 held-out harmful prompts of the proxy attention on harmful-span tokens, the cosine of the L36 last-token residual to $\hat{d}$, the next-token refusal-vocabulary probability sum P_{ref} , the next-token compliance-vocabulary probability sum P_{comp} , and the binary refusal label. The two **distractor** cells at $N \in \{128, 512\}$ are the only cells with $P_{\text{comp}} > 0.05$ (0.307 and 0.503 respectively); **prefix** keeps $P_{\text{comp}} = 0.000$ across the full grid. The attentional $\rightarrow$ behavioural $\rightarrow$ output-distribution chain agrees with the format-conditional collapse of Sections 7, 8 and 10.

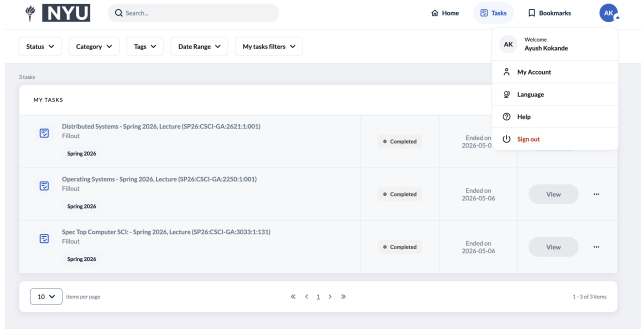


Figure 20: Course feedback submission, Ayush Kokande.

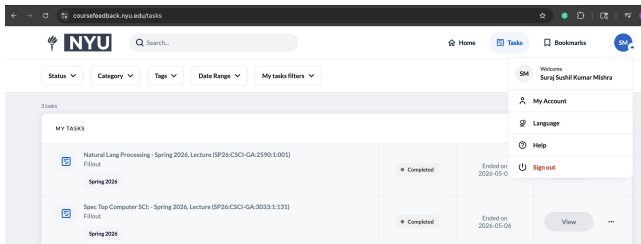


Figure 21: Course feedback submission, Suraj Mishra.